Telesphore Ndabamenye

(Ndah-bah-MEN-yeh)

Minister of Agriculture and Animal Resources
Republic of Rwanda

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **Dec 2025**

Telesphore Ndabamenye is an academic who has championed soil health and innovative programs to ascend to the top position in one of Rwanda's most politically important ministries.

- **Soil Star**
  Ndabamenye's background in soil science often prompts him to pitch soil health as critical to Rwanda's national security and prosperity. He has declared that "we have to feed our soils before we feed people."

- **Innovation Leader**
  Ndabamenye leans into Rwanda's reputation as a hub for innovation, affirming that he is "committed to rethink out of the box." He has backed the use of GMOs and endorsed digital platforms, such as Smart Nkunganire, to help farmers to manage targeting, subsidies, and data.

Ndabamenye is the third agriculture minister in less than three years, assuming the helm of a ministry under significant scrutiny for underperformance. The agriculture sector attracts constant political attention because it employs about 70 percent of the population and contributes 27 percent to GDP.

WHY THEY MATTER

Ndabamenye's top priority is to raise the yield per hectare through closer engagement with farmers, better extension services, and stronger ties with the private sector.

- **Yield Gains Through Inputs**
  Ndabamenye is working to realize Rwanda's goal to boost crop yields by 50 percent over the next five years. He has stressed the importance of timely, efficient distribution, and correct use of subsidized inputs.

- **Smart Investments Through Partnerships**
  The Minister has stressed that "leveraging science and modern technologies" is essential to promote food security. He has previously worked with the U.S. scientific and private sector, expressing enthusiasm for improved, stress resilient crops.

Ndabamenye has linked climate priorities, including cutting greenhouse emissions, to resilient and sustainable food systems. He often points to climate resilient agriculture goals in his public remarks.

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MEETING WITH THEM

Ndabamenye presents as a careful technocrat who favors inclusive language and occasionally reveals his passion when discussing soil chemistry or specific crops.

- **Pulling Together**
  The Minister has repeatedly underscored that “this is not one man’s job” and uses phases like “we need to,” “we have to,” and “we want to” to foster a sense of shared ownership and forward momentum.

- **Nerding out**
  Ndabamenye often marries his deep expertise on plant nutrition with an exuberance for certain crops. Earlier this year, he celebrated recent successes in scaling new potato varieties.

When responding to difficult questions, Ndabamenye is quick to acknowledge constraints (“We have been experiencing the inflation and the price hiking that remain critical as a major challenge") and add his own critiques (“Using blanket recommendations was like shooting in the air") before presenting solutions.

ON THEIR MIND

- **New Biotech Hub To Open**
  The Ministry in December announced plans to establish a center of excellence for crop biotechnology to develop and deploy disease-resistant seeds under a new five-year project.

- **Food Sovereignty Update**
  The National Institute of Statistics of Rwanda recently noted that the country's Self-Sufficiency Ratio (SSR) stood at 79.2 per cent in 2024, meaning Rwanda produces nearly four-fifths of the food required to feed its population.

- **South African Food Ban Lifted**
  Rwanda in November lifted a ban on some South African food products, including meat, dairy and milk products, and fruits and vegetables, that was put in place in 2017 because of a Listeria outbreak that sickened more than 1,000 people.

- **New Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) Plan**
  Rwanda in November released NDC 3.0, which targets agriculture as one of key sector for adaptation. It focuses on-farm water security with an increase in solar irrigation, combined with climate resilient seeds and livestock breeds.

NETWORK

Ndabamenye has strong ties to the international academic and scientific community, although his diplomatic relationships are still nascent.

Ndabamenye has had partnerships with several international partners in the R&D space, including Michigan State University; the Danforth Center Plant Science Center in St. Louis, Missouri; and Bayer, as well as academics in South Africa and Belgium. He has recently engaged with Israel's Ambassador to Rwanda.

While Ndabamenye's relationship with President Kagame appears more professional than personal, his appreciation for the president's leadership and inclusive approach to governance seems genuine.

Ndabamenye, who has expressed his gratitude to Kagame for his recent appointment, delivered a more emotional testimony during a ruling party campaign rally in 2024. He said that "in the past, the leaders of this country discriminated [against] us and took us for foreigners. You redesigned Rwanda to include Nyamasheke district."

CONTROVERSIES

While avoiding personal scandals, Ndabamenye's policy choices have generated tensions within Rwanda's agricultural community.

- **GMO Resistance**
  His promotion of genetically modified crops has faced resistance from organic farming advocates and traditional seed savers. A 2024 survey by Rwanda Organic Agriculture Movement found 62% of farmers expressed concerns about GMO adoption, though few publicly have voiced opposition given government support.

- **Food Basket Sites**
  Despite the Minister's support for the Food Basket Sites (FoBaSi) program, which groups farmers into priority production areas, there have been questions about performance and management, well as concerns about whether poorer farmers will be able to participate on equal terms.

The Rwanda Agriculture Board (RAB), where Ndabamenye held senior leadership roles, has periodically drawn political and oversight attention. Without implicating the Minister directly, past Auditor General audits and parliamentary hearings have cited governance and financial-control weaknesses, including contract-management problems and pricing/overpayment discrepancies.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Agriculture and Animal Resources**, Republic of Rwanda (2025 to present)
- **Minister of State for Agriculture and Animal Resources**, Republic of Rwanda (2024 to 2025)
- **Director-General**, Rwanda Agriculture and Animal Resources Development Board (2023 to 2024)
- **Africa Regional Platform Manager Food Action Alliance,** World Economic Forum (2021 to 2023)
- **Head of Crop Production and Food Security,** Rwanda Agriculture Board (2015 to 2021)
- **Chairperson of the Board of Directors,** Rwanda Environment Management Authority
- **Chairperson,** Nyamasheke District Council

BIO

Telesphore Ndabamenye's academic achievements and policy ascendency exemplifies his country's resilience in the aftermath of the Rwandan Genocide. Born in rural Nyamasheke, his first name is a reference to Saint Telesphorus, an early Pope, and to Telesphorus in Greek mythology, a child god of healing, symbolizing recovery and prosperity.

- **The Heights of the Academy**
  Ndabamenye holds a Ph.D. in Soil Science (Soil Science and Plant Nutrition), a MSc in Soil Science, and a BSc in Soil and Rural Engineering. His earliest academic publications focused on low-input East African highland bananas.

- **The Horrors of the Genocide**
  Ndabamenye in April 2024 discussed the terrible legacy of the Genocide at RAB, recalling that some of RAB's former leaders and employees had deviated from their duties to promote agriculture and livestock to kill their colleagues.

Ndabamenye is married to Uzayisenga Bellancile who received her PhD in plant pathology. They have four children and are devout Christians. The Minister speaks Kinyarwanda, English, and possibly French.